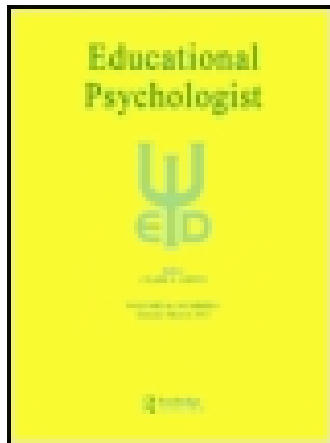


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Publisher: Routledge

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Educational Psychologist

Publication details, including instructions for authors and subscription information:

<http://www.tandfonline.com/loi/hedp20>

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Published online: 08 Jun 2010.

To cite this article: Patricia A. Alexander (2003) Coming Home: Educational Psychology's Philosophical Pilgrimage, Educational Psychologist, 38:3, 129-132, DOI: [10.1207/S15326985EP3803_1](https://doi.org/10.1207/S15326985EP3803_1)

To link to this article: http://dx.doi.org/10.1207/S15326985EP3803_1

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Coming Home: Educational Psychology's Philosophical Pilgrimage

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Certain perks come with serving as the president of Division 15 of the American Psychological Association (APA). Those perks include the opportunity to formulate a divisional theme for the annual meeting and to orchestrate a special session around that guiding theme, as well as the chance to extend an invitation to a distinguished keynote speaker. When those opportunities presented themselves in 2001, my decisions were relatively easy. I chose the theme "Getting in Touch" because several manifestations of this theme, such as building community, have long been important to me. Another aspect of getting in touch I wanted to highlight during my tenure was the rediscovery of our philosophical roots. I have long been surprised by how little some educational researchers and practitioners know about educational psychology's philosophical heritage. Further, I believe much is gained when we pay homage to our philosophical, as well as our psychological, roots. The achievements of today, after all, are built on those very foundations.

Because I believe the future of educational psychology rests, in part, on its past, I have entitled this opening "Coming Home." Even if this special issue achieves no other goal, it would be well worth the effort for the educational psychology community to turn an eye toward the wealth of wisdom found within the realm of philosophy. By coming home to philosophy, we can potentially infuse new ideas and alternative perspectives into ongoing educational research and practice. By coming home, we can reconsider the obvious merits of explicit philosophical inquiries, such as the study of epistemology, ontology, or axiology. In addition, we can glimpse the philosophical shading cast over mainstream educational psychology topics—from self-concept to achievement and from interest to perception. Yet this trip homeward should be more than a nostalgic foray into philosophy. Rather, it should become a pilgrimage—a journey into the past undertaken by

psychologists earnestly seeking to unearth the roots of their professional domain.

For these reasons, I asked Dr. John McDermott, preeminent scholar on William James and John Dewey, to be the presidential invited speaker at the 2001 conference. His insights about these two philosophical giants and their influence on educational theory and practice are unparalleled. He also is known as a "no-holds barred" philosopher who is not timid about laying bare controversial or unpleasant issues. I followed McDermott's keynote with a special session in his honor. This highlighted session included young scholars in educational psychology who paid tribute to their former teacher and mentor, while forwarding the theme of getting in touch with our philosophical roots.

I could not have been more pleased with the outcomes of those two events. Dr. McDermott's keynote was provocative and stimulating, and the subsequent special session was exceptional. You can judge the power of John McDermott's words for yourself; the transcript of his talk frames this special issue. I am especially grateful to Dr. P. Karen Murphy, editor of this special issue, for proposing and for stewarding this volume of the *Educational Psychologist*. It brings the merits of philosophical inquiry to a broader psychological audience. Even more than the conference theme and the two highlighted sessions, I am confident that this issue will do much to awaken members of the educational psychology community to the foundational and powerful relationship between philosophy and psychology.

PHILOSOPHY AND PSYCHOLOGY: A BRIEF RETROSPECTIVE

The official recognition of the discipline of educational psychology can be traced back to the same year that the APA was formally established under the leadership of G. Stanley Hall. Yet the roots of educational psychology were in place well before the establishment of APA. Those roots took the form of musings of individuals from varied fields of study voiced across the centuries. The taproot, however, was not in educa-

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tion or psychology; rather, the central root of educational psychology grew from the discipline of philosophy. In essence, musings about individual differences, assessment, development, motivation, problem solving, transfer, and the nature of subject matters have been the focus of thought and reflection since the presocratic philosophers.

For example, notable philosophers such as Plato and Aristotle (circa 400 BC) considered the kinds of education appropriate to different kinds of people; the formation of good character and virtue; the development of the individual; the development of rhetoric, persuasive thinking, and reasoning; the methods of teaching; the relationship between the teacher and student; the nature of learning; and the order of learning. Comenius (1592–1671), a philosopher and minister, was the first individual to write texts based on developmental theory. In them he used visual aids for instructional purposes. Comenius wrote a text for multiple content areas because he believed that students learned differently in the various content areas. Rousseau's (1712–1778) contributions to education also were developmental in nature. Rousseau wrote on the importance of natural development of children; he believed that the gravest of errors was to think about what adults ought to know instead of what children are capable of knowing.

Of course, the contributions of these philosophers to educational psychology only begin to scratch the surface. Many classical American philosophers including, William James, John Dewey, and Charles Peirce, were as much psychologists as they were philosophers. Both James and Dewey believed that psychology was a philosophic method of inquiry that could be used to ponder theory, explore hypotheses, and compare alternatives (McDermott, 1977). Therefore, at the turn of the 20th century, philosophy was shaping education through psychological method. Certainly a noteworthy example was Dewey's Chicago School—an educational experience duplicated across the United States.

What is evident, however, is that educational psychology has, in many ways, lost its ties to philosophy. Revisiting the history of the relationship between philosophy and educational theory and research can help explain that estrangement. I chose the word estrangement because I see the bonds between philosophy and educational practice as analogous to a fluctuating and fragile personal relationship. As noted, a small cadre of pragmatic philosophers in the early years of the 20th century became committed to bringing their collective wisdom to bear on learning and academic development. At this point in their relationship, the association between philosophy and educational psychology, although strong, was rather one sided and untested. It was the philosophers who became enamored with education and who pursued those in educational practice, seeking to convince them of the intellectual dowry they would bring to this new partnership.

Before long, however, with the rise of influence by Edward L. Thorndike and his contemporaries, this tenuous relationship suffered (Berliner, 1993). In effect, Thorndike and his followers believed that educational inquiry had to be “sci-

entific.” This push toward the scientific study of education meant that there was little appreciation for either the vagaries and abstractions of philosophical inquiry or the inherent dynamism and organized chaos inherent in the classroom. Such views helped to narrow the philosophical orientations deemed acceptable to educational theory and practice and initiated what Berliner describes as a period of disdain between psychology and educational practice.

Researchers in the latter part of the 20th century gradually reawakened to the power and beauty of educational research undertaken *in situ*. This appreciation for the educational enterprise grew, not despite the unpredictability or complexity found in learning environments but because of it. An interest in philosophy grew simultaneously within the educational psychology community. This special issue is evidence of that budding awareness and appreciation.

PHILOSOPHY AND CURRENT EDUCATIONAL THEORY AND PRACTICE: CONTEMPORARY PERSPECTIVES

In the early years of this new millennium, as the field of educational psychology continues to define its place within the educational enterprise, it is imperative that we reflect on the foundations of our domain. I trust that this volume can help keep the lessons of the past squarely in our minds and thus contribute to needed reflection and subsequent dialogue on the proper place of philosophy in the stream of educational psychology. The contents are both diverse and well conceived, beginning with McDermott's talk to educational psychologists. That talk is suitably complemented by four articles that recognize certain of McDermott's compelling issues. The depth and variety of those articles, along with the insightful commentaries by Pajares and Burbules, are touchstones for educational psychologists interested in the roots of the domain and in the links between current trends and philosophical thought.

A Talk to Educational Psychologists

Within his opening message, McDermott narrows philosophy's vast tapestry into select issues relevant to the core relationship between philosophy and educational psychology. For instance, he questions whether the profession's goals of (a) defining or operationalizing educational constructs and (b) seeking answers to important educational questions can be reconciled with the nature of philosophical thought. He also asks whether human history has a meaning other than what we impose on it and whether essences, objects, and platonic forms are fixed in nature or merely human constructions. In responding to those questions, McDermott draws on

philosophical existentialism, particularly the thoughts of Albert Camus and the radical empiricism of James.

The Homage

McDermott's perplexing issues are echoed in the four articles that follow. For example, Murphy begins with an examination of what she describes as American philosophy's greatest gift to educational psychology—pragmatism. She also explores ways in which educational psychologists currently employ philosophical thought. This exploration involves a thoughtful examination of the writings of Charles Peirce.

The works of Peirce, a less familiar member of the American metaphysical group, are the primary means by which Murphy brings pragmatism to the foreground and demonstrates its pertinence to many of the questions that currently occupy educators' minds and fill our professional journals. Although Murphy describes pragmatism as one of the most influential philosophical theories in the past century, she also recognizes its paradoxical nature—an amulet and albatross for educational psychology. In her article, Murphy thoughtfully discusses this dualistic nature of pragmatism and the consequences for the ever-volatile relationship between philosophy, psychology, and education.

Later in this volume, Rosiek continues this focus on pragmatism, this time with an emphasis on educational methodology. As he argues, educational psychology was once a methodologically diverse field. Yet the behaviorist revolution, with its emphasis on quantitative data, instituted a more constrained methodological vista with its operationalized variables and positivist epistemologies. Even the cognitive revolution could not completely break free from behaviorism's narrow epistemic and methodological boundaries.

Rosiek turns to classical pragmatic philosophers to construct a more encompassing methodological frame for educational psychology. His premise is that psychologists may be relatively familiar with pragmatic insights about the human condition. However, according to Rosiek, they may be unfamiliar with or overlook pragmatic notions about how those insights can be or should be derived. Such an oversight can be forgiven, in part, because pragmatists, such as Peirce, James, and Dewey, never developed explicit research methodologies. However, Rosiek draws on pragmatic philosophy to outline principles that can foster a more open, experience-based research methodology.

Compared with the other articles, Kulikowich and DeFranco consider the relationship between philosophy and psychology from a more domain-specific vantage point. The internal conflict in the relationship between philosophy and psychology fomented by psychology's search for specificity in psychological definitions and educational constructs raised in McDermott's remarks is strongly echoed in the Kulikowich and DeFranco article. Here the authors discuss how such tensions and debate are not limited to psychology

but have been similarly manifest in the discipline of mathematics.

As Kulikowich and DeFranco rightly note, many individuals equate mathematics with rigor and exactness. In reality, however, the philosophy of mathematics reveals considerable disagreement among prominent thinkers. Cantor, Frege, and Kronecker, for example, waged many academic battles over defining terms such as number, set, and infinity. Kulikowich and DeFranco conclude that the histories and philosophies of mathematics and educational psychology afford a cross-disciplinary examination of the philosophical debates and dialogues integral to any complex domain.

Finally, Woods tackles one of the most unsettling issues to face educational researchers and practitioners and one of the topics that is a hallmark of philosophical discourse—*veritas* or truth. Although there are few educational studies expressly dedicated to the study of truth, truth is inextricably tied to various lines of psychological research, as Woods makes apparent. I certainly found this to be true. My colleagues and my research in conceptual change and persuasion (Alexander, 2001; Murphy & Alexander, 2002), the nature of knowledge and beliefs (Alexander & Dochy, 1995; Buehl, Alexander, & Murphy, 2002), and the structure of academic domains (Alexander, 1998) are just three areas where conceptions and perceptions of truth play a significant role.

Final Thoughts

There can be no more suitable conclusion to this excellent volume than the commentaries by Pajares and Burbules, two respected educational scholars intimately familiar with philosophical schools and writings. I leave it to those two colleagues to critique and extend the contents of the articles that anchor this special issue. It is clear, however, that their alternative viewpoints and their grounded insights have heightened the value of this volume to the educational psychology community. Collectively, these commentaries, along with the opening talk and complementary articles, bring my goal of getting in touch with our philosophical heritage closer to becoming a reality.

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